

Hong Kong Exchanges (0388.HK): 2Q26 Review: Robust equities franchise with attractive structural upsides; Buy (on CL)

HKEX's 2Q26 profit came in ahead of GSe/company compiled consensus. Around half of the beat was driven by non-recurring investment gains from unlisted equities. Excluding investment income, profit was 7% ahead of GSe, driven by better-than-expected cash equities segment results, partially offset by weaker equity derivatives revenue.

Based on our conversations, we believe investors were encouraged by better-than-expected cash equities segment revenue. Management flagged a robust IPO pipeline and continued conversion from pipeline into listings. As we highlighted previously, ADT contribution from newly listed companies (since 2025) has risen above 10%. With a record IPO pipeline and strong returns for the newly listed companies, we believe this forms a strong platform for ADT growth in 2H26.

Questions from investors focused mainly on OPEX, as underlying OPEX increased 9% yoy, after excluding the HK\$90mn FCA fine paid in 1H25. Staff cost and IT-related spending were the main drivers, +10%/+8% yoy, as HKEX continues to invest in capabilities. We believe this is driven by the build out to support the development of a multi-asset ecosystem and raise our OPEX estimates by 3% in FY26-29E. The key, in our view, is whether this build out is rewarded with new sources of revenue, especially given the focus on FIC opportunities. HKEX highlighted the transition from strategy-setting to execution for the FIC business, with encouraging early traction. Structurally, we continue to see FIC product offerings as the next leg of the growth engine for HKEX.

We fine-tune our estimates for FY26-29E, incorporating higher revenue and OPEX estimates. Our 12-month 3-stage DDM-based target price is HK\$540 (unchanged), implying 34X FY27E P/E. With HKEX now trading at 26X FY27E P/E, below its mid-cycle P/E of 33X, we continue to see attractive risk/reward. Reiterate Buy (on CL).

We summarize below our key takeaways from the results briefing:

- **Fundraising:** Mgmt highlighted that the IPO pipeline remains robust, with YTD fundraising of US\$42bn as of July, exceeding the FY25 total of US\$37bn. The IPO pipeline remains healthy and diversified across technology, AI, biotech, industrials and consumer sectors, while interest from international and homecoming listings continues to build. HKEX also noted strong follow-on fundraising YTD, on track to deliver better performance compared to last year.

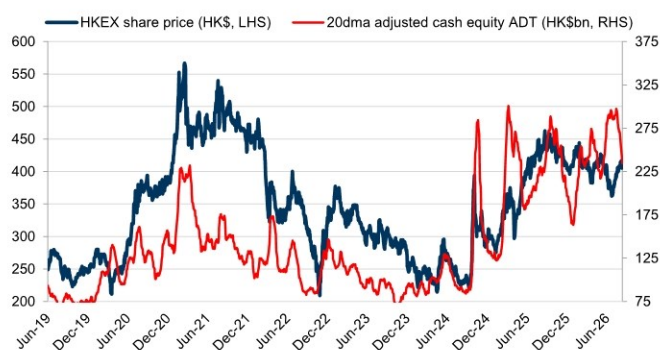
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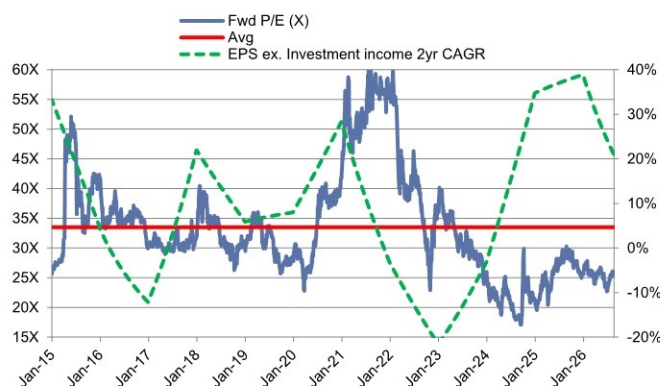
- **Strengthened connectivity:** Mgmt reiterated that expanding connectivity remains one of the key strategy priorities, and HKEX continues to focus on attracting more participants, broadening eligible product offerings and enhancing market infrastructure. Recent developments include green light for mainland insurers to invest in Hong Kong-listed ETFs through stock connect, and HKEX expects more initiatives to be announced.
- **FIC opportunities:** Mgmt believes HKEX is now shifting from strategy-setting to execution in its FIC business, with encouraging early traction across fixed income and commodities segments. The recent launch of offshore CGB futures has attracted strong institutional interest, while mgmt highlights broadening participation across the ecosystem, including from large asset managers. HKEX expects further ecosystem development through the upcoming acceptance of CGBs as clearing collateral by year-end, expanded product suite, and enhanced repo arrangements. These initiatives should support higher trading activity across the broader fixed income franchise.
- **Technology and operational investments:** Underlying OPEX increased 9% yoy in 1H26, as HKEX continues to invest in talent and capabilities to support its multi-asset ecosystem strategy. HKEX continues to focus on trading and post-trade service enhancements, including ODP (Orion Derivatives Platform), OCP (Orion Cash Platform), and initiatives related to tokenisation and digital payments. Looking ahead, HKEX expects the launch of derivatives clearing houses client margin enhancements in September and Uncertificated Securities Market (USM) in November.

Exhibit 1: Market ADT recorded strong growth in recent months



Source: Bloomberg, Datastream

Exhibit 2: HKEX is trading at 26X 1-year forward P/E, below mid-cycle P/E of 33X



Source: Datastream, Company data, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 3: HKEX estimate change summary

Revised and prior estimates for HKEX
(HK\$ mn)

(HK\$mn)	2026E		2027E		2028E		2029E		chg %				vs. cons %			
	Prior	Revised	Prior	Revised	Prior	Revised	Prior	Revised	2026E	2027E	2028E	2029E	2026E	2027E	2028E	2029E
Trading fees and trading tariff	11,967	12,024	12,498	12,513	13,367	13,385	14,263	14,284	0.5%	0.1%	0.1%	0.1%	1.9%	1.8%	4.1%	3.6%
Stock Exchange listing fees	2,044	2,075	2,185	2,239	2,294	2,342	2,308	2,364	1.5%	2.5%	2.1%	2.4%	5.2%	7.3%	3.5%	-0.6%
Clearing and settlement fees	8,561	8,723	8,747	8,728	9,403	9,339	10,117	10,050	1.9%	-0.2%	-0.7%	-0.7%	7.2%	3.3%	3.1%	0.6%
Depository, custody and nominee services fees	1,638	1,760	1,776	1,827	1,923	1,978	2,033	2,092	7.5%	2.9%	2.9%	2.9%	6.1%	5.0%	4.1%	-6.1%
Market data fees	1,248	1,264	1,298	1,315	1,350	1,367	1,404	1,422	1.3%	1.3%	1.3%	1.3%	0.6%	-0.2%	-1.0%	1.4%
Other revenue	2,099	2,106	2,267	2,274	2,448	2,456	2,644	2,652	0.3%	0.3%	0.3%	0.3%	-5.8%	-3.3%	-1.3%	1.9%
Investment income and other income	4,389	4,674	4,089	4,245	4,119	4,348	4,228	4,453	6.5%	3.8%	5.6%	5.3%	7.8%	5.9%	9.4%	16.1%
Total income	31,947	32,627	32,860	33,141	34,905	35,216	36,996	37,317	2.1%	0.9%	0.9%	0.9%	3.4%	2.3%	3.3%	1.7%
Operating expenses (ex. D&A)	6,636	6,846	7,028	7,248	7,442	7,673	7,879	8,121	3.2%	3.1%	3.1%	3.1%				
Operating expenses (in. D&A)	8,328	8,514	8,855	9,049	9,415	9,618	10,010	10,222	2.2%	2.2%	2.2%	2.1%	1.6%	2.3%	3.7%	3.6%
EBITDA	25,310	25,780	25,832	25,893	27,463	27,543	29,117	29,196	1.9%	0.2%	0.3%	0.3%	4.2%	4.2%	5.4%	5.7%
Depreciation & amortisation	1,692	1,668	1,827	1,801	1,973	1,946	2,131	2,101	-1.4%	-1.4%	-1.4%	-1.4%				
Pretax profit	23,563	24,054	23,949	24,032	25,432	25,536	26,927	27,033	2.1%	0.3%	0.4%	0.4%	4.5%	2.7%	3.6%	1.0%
Attributable profit	19,763	20,177	20,102	20,186	21,350	21,452	22,608	22,711	2.1%	0.4%	0.5%	0.5%	4.1%	2.5%	3.4%	0.7%
Profits ex investment income	15,374	15,503	16,014	15,941	17,231	17,103	18,380	18,258	0.8%	-0.5%	-0.7%	-0.7%				
EPS (HK\$)	15.63	15.96	15.90	15.97	16.89	16.97	17.88	17.97	2.1%	0.5%	0.5%	0.5%	4.0%	2.8%	3.7%	1.1%
DPS (HK\$)	14.07	14.28	14.31	14.38	15.20	15.28	16.09	16.17	1.5%	0.5%	0.5%	0.5%	3.9%	2.9%	3.8%	1.8%
Local market ADT ex Southbound (HK\$ bn)	217	221	222	222	236	236	251	251	1.8%	0.3%	0.3%	0.3%				
Local market ADT incl SB (HK\$ bn)	284	284	298	295	320	316	342	337	0.1%	-1.3%	-1.3%	-1.3%	2.9%	4.4%	7.2%	4.1%
Northbound ADT (RMBbn, both sides)	308.9	310.1	308.3	308.6	340.0	340.3	379.9	380.2	0.4%	0.1%	0.1%	0.1%	5.6%	2.3%	7.4%	-0.9%
Southbound ADT (HK\$bn, both sides)	133.9	126.3	153.4	144.8	168.8	159.3	182.3	172.0	-5.6%	-5.6%	-5.6%	-5.6%	-3.0%	3.9%	4.0%	6.8%
HKEX DDAV ('000 contracts)	1,756	1,763	1,894	1,901	2,051	2,059	2,204	2,212	0.4%	0.4%	0.4%	0.4%	-3.0%	-2.9%	-5.5%	-11.5%
LME DDAV ('000 contracts)	832	790	840	793	871	822	903	852	-5.1%	-5.7%	-5.7%	-5.7%				

Source: Visible Alpha Consensus Data, Company data, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 4: HKEX financials summary

HKEX Summary sheet																											
Price HK\$540.0																											
Summary sheet																											
HK\$mn, unless otherwise mentioned		2019	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024	2025	2026E	2027E	2028E	2029E	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024	2025	2026E	2027E	2028E	2029E	CAGR 14-24	CAGR 24-29E		
Key earnings drivers																											
Cash equity ADT (incl. DW/CBBC, HK\$bn)																											
Total (excl. SB)	82	118	148	110	90	109	191	221	222	236	251	-19%	44%	25%	-26%	-18%	21%	76%	15%	1%	6%	6%		5%	18%		
Total (incl. SB)	87	129	167	125	105	132	250	284	295	316	337	-19%	49%	29%	-25%	-16%	26%	90%	14%	4%	7%	7%		7%	21%		
SB (gross buy+sell)	10.1	22.2	38.0	29.4	29.6	45.6	116.6	126.3	144.8	159.3	172.0	-12%	120%	71%	-23%	1%	54%	156%	8%	15%	10%	8%		84%	30%		
NB (gross buy+sell)	43.6	96.1	134.8	113.6	124.1	170.6	245.5	372.1	370.3	408.3	456.3	109%	120%	40%	-16%	9%	38%	44%	52%	0%	10%	12%		70%	22%		
Derivatives DDAV ('000 contracts)																											
HKEX F&O	1,069	1,138	1,185	1,303	1,364	1,560	1,670	1,763	1,901	2,059	2,212	-11%	6%	4%	10%	5%	14%	7%	6%	8%	8%		7%	10%	7%		
LME	618	573	559	507	562	665	717	790	793	822	852	1%	-7%	-2%	-9%	11%	18%	8%	10%	0%	4%	4%		0%	5%		
Blended investment yield	1.62%	1.16%	0.63%	0.60%	2.08%	2.32%	2.39%	1.63%	1.22%	1.14%	1.22%													4%	-12%		
Summary P&L (HK\$mn)																											
Total revenue	16,311	19,190	20,950	18,456	20,516	22,374	29,161	32,627	33,141	35,216	37,317	3%	18%	9%	-12%	11%	9%	30%	12%	2%	6%	6%		9%	11%		
Trading fees and trading tariff	5,592	6,959	7,931	6,837	6,081	7,189	10,333	12,024	12,513	13,385	14,284	-12%	24%	14%	-14%	-11%	18%	44%	16%	4%	7%	7%		7%	15%		
Cash	1,878	3,278	4,369	3,246	2,622	3,278	5,948	7,222	7,660	8,192	8,752	-12%	75%	33%	-26%	-19%	25%	81%	21%	6%	7%	7%		7%	22%		
Cash equity Connect	283	611	910	760	747	890	1,634	2,115	2,216	2,441	2,686	52%	116%	49%	-16%	-2%	19%	84%	29%	5%	10%	10%		69%	25%		
Equity and Financial Derivatives	2,678	2,592	2,490	2,614	2,393	2,499	2,823	2,974	3,048	3,321	3,593	-14%	-3%	-4%	5%	-8%	4%	13%	5%	2%	9%	8%		7%	8%		
Commodities	1,036	1,089	1,072	977	1,066	1,412	1,562	1,828	1,805	1,871	1,939	-3%	5%	-2%	-9%	9%	32%	11%	17%	-1%	4%	4%		4%	7%		
Stock Exchange listing fees	1,633	1,899	2,185	1,915	1,523	1,484	1,789	2,075	2,239	2,342	2,364	-5%	16%	15%	-12%	-20%	-3%	21%	16%	8%	5%	1%		3%	10%		
Clearing and settlement fees	3,160	4,355	5,214	4,335	3,885	4,717	7,042	8,723	8,728	9,339	10,050	-4%	38%	20%	-17%	-10%	21%	49%	24%	0%	7%	8%		9%	16%		
Cash	2,652	3,848	4,726	3,891	3,398	4,085	6,333	7,903	7,926	8,550	9,231	-4%	45%	23%	-18%	-13%	20%	55%	25%	0%	8%	8%		8%	18%		
Cash equity Connect	332	721	1,003	828	876	1,254	2,163	3,007	3,099	3,414	3,776	62%	117%	39%	-17%	6%	43%	73%	39%	3%	10%	11%		73%	25%		
Commodities	508	507	488	444	487	632	709	820	802	790	819	-2%	0%	-4%	-9%	10%	30%	12%	16%	-2%	-2%	4%		13%	5%		
Depository, custody and nominee	1,052	1,264	1,543	1,260	1,276	1,146	1,503	1,760	1,827	1,978	2,092	7%	20%	22%	-18%	1%	-10%	31%	17%	4%	8%	6%		5%	13%		
Market data fees	919	953	1,034	1,081	1,098	1,086	1,171	1,264	1,315	1,367	1,422	2%	4%	8%	5%	2%	-1%	8%	8%	4%	4%	4%		4%	6%		
Other revenue	1,209	1,405	1,564	1,506	1,582	1,724	1,907	2,106	2,274	2,456	2,652	17%	16%	11%	-4%	5%	9%	11%	10%	8%	8%	8%		8%	9%		
Investment income and other income	2,746	2,355	1,479	1,522	5,071	5,028	5,416	4,674	4,245	4,348	4,453	70%	-14%	-37%	3%	233%	-1%	8%	-14%	-9%	2%	2%		21%	-2%		
Operating expenses	4,048	4,549	4,681	5,271	5,688	6,093	6,365	6,846	7,248	7,673	8,121	-2%	12%	3%	13%	8%	7%	4%	8%	6%	6%	6%		7%	6%		
EBITDA	12,263	14,641	16,269	13,185	14,828	16,281	22,796	25,780	25,893	27,543	29,196	4%	19%	11%	-19%	12%	10%	40%	13%	0%	6%	6%		9%	12%		
Pretax profit	10,951	13,332	14,841	11,659	13,332	14,853	21,158	24,054	24,032	25,536	27,033	1%	22%	11%	-21%	14%	11%	42%	14%	0%	6%	6%		9%	13%		
Attributable profit	9,391	11,505	12,535	10,078	11,862	13,050	17,754	20,177	20,186	21,452	22,711	1%	23%	9%	-20%	18%	10%	36%	14%	0%	6%	6%		10%	12%		
Profit ex invt income	6,645	9,150	11,056	8,556	6,791	8,022	12,338	15,593	15,941	17,103	18,258	-14%	38%	21%	-23%	-21%	18%	54%	26%	3%	7%	7%		6%	18%		
Basic EPS (HK\$)	7.49	9.10	9.91	7.96	9.37	10.32	14.05	15.96	15.97	16.97	17.97	0%	22%	9%	-20%	18%	10%	36%	14%	0%	6%	6%		9%	12%		
DPS (HK\$)	6.71	8.15	8.87	7.14	8.41	9.26	12.52	14.28	14.38	15.28	16.17	0%	22%	9%	-20%	18%	10%	35%	14%	1%	6%	6%		9%	12%		
Key metrics																											
Cost income (incl. depreciation)		31%	30%	29%	36%	35%	33%	27%	26%	27%	27%																
EBITDA margin	75%	76%	78%	71%	72%	73%	78%	79%	78%	78%	78%																
Operating margin	69%	70%	71%	64%	65%	67%	73%	74%	74%	73%	73%																
NPAT margin	58%	60%	60%	55%	58%	58%	61%	62%	61%	61%	61%																
ROE	22%	25%	25%	20%	23%	25%	32%	33%	32%	33%	33%																
Valuation																											
P/E	55X	46X	42X	52X	44X	40X		30X	26X	26X	24X	23X															
P/E (excl. investment income)								42X	34X	33X	31X	29X															
P/B (excl. investment income)								0.5X	1.0X	9.2X	3.3X	3.4X															
P/B		15.3X	14.0X	13.8X	13.7X	13.2X	12.9X	12.0X	11.3X	11.0X	10.6X	9.9X															
Dividend yield, %	1.2	1.5	1.6	1.3	1.6	1.7	2.3	2.6	2.6	2.7	2.8	3.0															

0388.HK	12m Price Target: HK\$540.00	Price: HK\$414.60	Upside: 30.2%
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Buy 		GS Forecast			
Market cap: HK\$524.2bn / \$66.8bn 3m ADTV: HK\$1.8bn / \$226.4mn Hong Kong Greater China Financials M&A Rank: 3	Revenue (HK\$ mn) New	12/25	12/26E	12/27E	12/28E
		29,161.0	32,626.5	33,141.1	35,215.6
	Revenue (HK\$ mn) Old	29,161.0	31,946.6	32,859.8	34,904.7
	EPS (HK\$) New	14.05	15.96	15.97	16.97
	EPS (HK\$) Old	14.05	15.63	15.90	16.89
	P/E (X)	27.8	26.0	26.0	24.4
	P/B (X)	8.5	8.6	8.2	8.1
	ROE (%)	31.7	33.9	32.4	33.4
	DPS (HK\$)	12.52	14.28	14.38	15.28
	Dividend yield (%)	3.2	3.4	3.5	3.7
		3/26	6/26	9/26E	12/26E
EPS (HK\$)		4.10	4.26	4.11	3.49

Source: Company data, Goldman Sachs Research estimates, FactSet. Price as of 19 Aug 2026 close.

Disclosure Appendix

Reg AC

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Growth is based on a stock's forward-looking sales growth, EBITDA growth and EPS growth (for financial stocks, only EPS and sales growth), with a higher percentile indicating a higher growth company. **Financial Returns** is based on a stock's forward-looking ROE, ROCE and CROCI (for financial stocks, only ROE), with a higher percentile indicating a company with higher financial returns. **Multiple** is based on a stock's forward-looking P/E, P/B, price/dividend (P/D), EV/EBITDA, EV/FCF and EV/Debt Adjusted Cash Flow (DACF) (for financial stocks, only P/E, P/B and P/D), with a higher percentile indicating a stock trading at a higher multiple. The **Integrated** percentile is calculated as the average of the Growth percentile, Financial Returns percentile and (100% - Multiple percentile).

Financial Returns and Multiple use the Goldman Sachs analyst forecasts at the fiscal year-end at least three quarters in the future. Growth uses inputs for the fiscal year at least seven quarters in the future compared with the year at least three quarters in the future (on a per-share basis for all metrics).

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Distribution of ratings/investment banking relationships

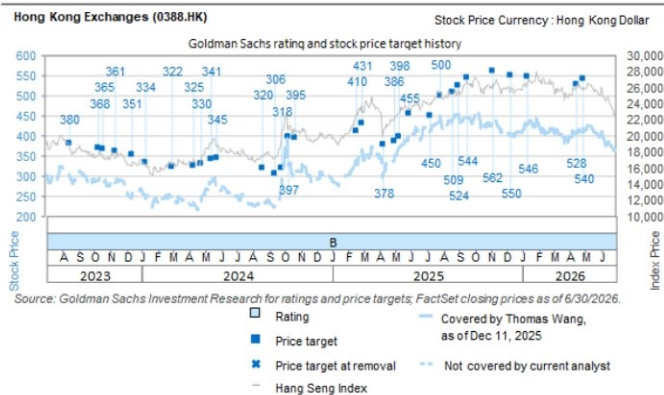
Goldman Sachs Investment Research global Equity coverage universe

	Rating Distribution				Investment Banking Relationships		
	Buy	Hold	Sell		Buy	Hold	Sell
Global	50%	34%	16%		65%	59%	43%

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Price target and rating history chart(s)



The price targets shown should be considered in the context of all prior published Goldman Sachs research, which may or may not have included price targets, as well as developments relating to the company, its industry and financial markets.

Target price history table(s) Hong Kong Exchanges (0388.HK)

Date of report	Target price (HK\$)	Closing price (HK\$)
29-Apr-26	540.00	419.80
15-Apr-26	528.00	414.00
12-Jan-26	546.00	426.20
11-Dec-25	550.00	400.80
05-Nov-25	562.00	423.60
18-Sep-25	544.00	444.00
01-Sep-25	524.00	454.00
20-Aug-25	509.00	441.20
28-Jul-25	500.00	449.40
08-Jul-25	450.00	417.40
30-May-25	455.00	395.80
09-May-25	398.00	372.40
30-Apr-25	386.00	340.80
10-Apr-25	378.00	306.80
27-Feb-25	431.00	365.00
17-Feb-25	410.00	340.80
23-Oct-24	395.00	314.80
10-Oct-24	397.00	334.20
27-Sep-24	318.00	308.60
13-Sep-24	306.00	224.00
21-Aug-24	320.00	228.60
24-May-24	345.00	274.00
14-May-24	341.00	284.40
24-Apr-24	330.00	239.00
10-Apr-24	325.00	234.60
29-Feb-24	322.00	242.80
08-Jan-24	334.00	247.80
13-Dec-23	351.00	247.20
13-Nov-23	361.00	285.60
20-Oct-23	365.00	285.20
11-Oct-23	368.00	292.00

Price targets shown in table(s) are unadjusted for corporate actions.

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